future. A great deal, though was not written everywhere. If some of his records were expansive, others were concise, and still others of a medium form. For the long records, as in this case, one reason for their elaborate form is that ‘there are (some topics which) have been repeated over and over again owing to their sweetness, so that people may act accordingly.’[47] On the other hand, their abridgement is in many instances deliberate because a particular place may have seemed unsuitable for the full record. In some, the king acknowledges, a poor scribe had put down an incomplete record. In any case, all types of records, we are told had not been placed in their complete form in all places.

Looking at this anthology as a whole and in relation to his first message, Ashoka will now have appeared to his subjects in a somewhat different way. While in his first message the emperor showed his conversion to Buddhism as instrumental in his political life, that connection is now no longer overt: the repentance over Kalinga is now central. In the minor edicts a broad-based morality rooted in tradition was disseminated. Now the emphasis changes into the necessity of transparent governance. The writ of state is not laid down, but the emperor takes trouble to elucidate the spiritual basis of his political interventions.

That this constitutes a unique political intervention is worth underlining. Empires make their presence felt in the archaeological record in various ways. Kings frequently and literally coined their presence over their dominion—for instance, the Indo-Greek rulers’ coins bear their names in Greek, and on the obverse in Prakrit. Other empires sculpted their rulers in stone. The Kushana kings were particularly partial to this, the iconic image of the empire being the martial representation of a belted and booted King Kanishka, his hand on the hilt of his sword. Of yet others, the regal presence is made apparent through the use of seals inscribed with the names and administrative designations of a governing class: those of the Gupta